

The Washington Post

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Partly sunny 66/49 • Tomorrow: Showers 66/42 **B6**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, FEBRUARY 26, 2025 • \$4

DOGE's data grab raises fears on privacy

Actions by Musk's team could expose Americans' information, experts say

BY FAIZ SIDDIQUI,
JOSEPH MENN
AND JACOB BOGAGE

Deputies of Elon Musk have sought access to massive amounts of information across the federal government, much of it personal and highly revelatory in its insights into the lives of everyday Americans.

They justify their work for the U.S. DOGE Service as a dogged quest for government efficiency. But people with deep knowledge of federal data systems and cybersecurity say they're skirting guardrails meant to protect sensitive data from misuse.

Before DOGE launched, most of the records at issue were kept in the hands of a select few officials to preserve privacy and avoid crossing legal red lines. Now Musk's group is seeking often-unfettered access, citing suspicion of fraud and waste. In addition to concerns about exposing private

SEE **DOGE** ON **A4**

Internal dissent: Musk escalates power struggle with Trump aides. **A8**

Firings reversed: Some HHS workers were asked to return. **A18**

Buyer's remorse: CEO causes some to regret driving a Tesla. **B1**

Framework emerges on Ukraine minerals

Deal to help U.S. recoup aid costs follows days of pressure by Trump

BY SIOBHÁN O'GRADY
AND MICHAEL BIRNBAUM

KYIV — Ukraine and the United States have agreed to a framework for an expansive minerals deal, according to a Ukrainian official and another person familiar with the matter, potentially easing weeks of bitterness from President Donald Trump directed toward Kyiv.

The broad outlines of the deal would grant Washington partial access to Ukraine's minerals, oil and gas, part of an effort by the Trump administration to recoup the cost of U.S. war aid and, advocates of a deal say, offer a form of security to Ukraine by deepening U.S. investments there.

The idea originated in a plan floated by Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky last year, in which his country's untapped mineral wealth would be used to help fund its war effort. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent brought a plan to Kyiv this month that shocked Ukrainian officials because it demanded unchecked access to their country's resources but offered little in return. One person compared it to a 19th-century imperial demand for resource extraction from a colony.

But after days of negotiations, the Ukrainian government ap-

SEE **UKRAINE** ON **A18**

Syrians chart a path after fall of Bashar al-Assad



SALWAN GEORGES/THE WASHINGTON POST

People walk on a main street in the Mezze 86 neighborhood of Damascus on Tuesday as hundreds of Syrian politicians and activists gathered for a national dialogue aimed at mapping out the country's political transition, nearly three months after President Bashar al-Assad fled in the face of a rebel advance. **Story, A11**

Allegation of anti-straight bias could remake law

BY JUSTIN JOUVENAL
AND TAYLOR TELFORD

AKRON, OHIO — Marlean Ames was distraught in 2019 when she was bumped from an administrator position at the state agency overseeing youth corrections and replaced by a gay man who she says was less qualified.

Ames was demoted, and her pay was cut more than \$40,000. A few months later, she lost a management job she had applied for

to a woman who had not sought the position initially, according to a lawsuit Ames would soon file. That woman, too, was gay.

Ames's job discrimination lawsuit makes an unusual claim that could upend how many of the nation's courts have handled such cases for decades: The department, she says, was biased against straight people like her.

The Supreme Court will hear oral arguments Wednesday in Ames's bid to revive her case,

Supreme Court will hear Ohio case with potential to unleash flood of claims

which was stymied in the lower courts because of past rulings that set a higher legal bar for men, straight people and Whites to prove bias in the workplace than for groups that have historically

faced discrimination. That higher standard is unconstitutional, her suit says.

The case is being closely watched by corporations and employment lawyers, many of whom expect the high court's conservative supermajority to side with Ames, now 60, and make it easier for members of majority groups to sue.

"If she wins, the flood of reverse discrimination claims will

SEE **BIAS** ON **A6**

In remote Suriname, a shadowy trade in jaguar parts to China

BY NICK MIROFF AND
CAROLYN VAN HOUTEN
IN PARAMARIBO, SURINAME

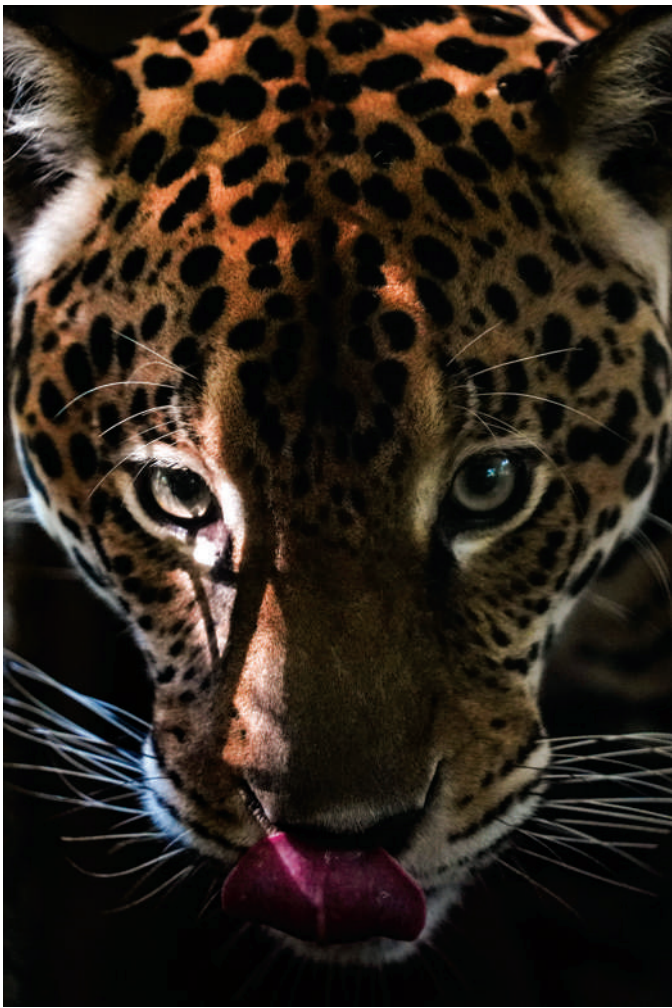
The meeting place was a restaurant not far from the blinking casinos along the wide muddy river. Andrea Crosta and Mark Davis took a table on the outdoor patio, looking somewhat out of place. They were foreigners in a small South American country with few tourists. Vegetarians at a barbecue grill.

Sitting nearby was their best undercover operative, Alpha. He was dining with that day's target, a Chinese currency trader with ties to a wildlife-trafficking network. Alpha's phone was face down on the table, but its microphone was on and its fish-eye lens was recording.

Alpha wanted to know about jaguars. How much for fangs? What about a large male carcass?

Crosta, a few tables away, spoke in a hushed voice, though he was safely out of earshot. He is the founder of Earth League International (ELI), a small nonprofit based in Los Angeles that is one of the world's most unusual animal welfare organizations. He, Alpha and Davis, the group's intelligence chief and a former FBI agent, were in Suriname to investigate jaguar smuggling and pass the information along to the U.S. Department of Homeland

SEE **JAGUARS** ON **A12**



CAROLYN VAN HOUTEN/THE WASHINGTON POST

A rescued jaguar at Suriname's Paramaribo Zoo. Smuggling jaguar parts out of the country is among Chinese criminal groups' various illegal enterprises in Latin America.

Strip searches, isolation in Guantánamo prison

Migrants detained there before deportation say some attempted suicide

BY SILVIA FOSTER-FRAU
AND ANA VANESSA HERRERO

He couldn't tell when the days started and ended within the windowless, peeling yellow four walls of his prison cell in Guantánamo.

Diuvar Uzcátegui kept track of them by putting a small tear in the last, blank page of a Bible after every third meal. The book was given to him by the military guards along with a blanket and a three-quarter-inch foam pad to sleep on. He went to the bathroom in a bucket connected to a tap in the cell.

And though he couldn't see his fellow detainees, he could hear them.

Some screamed. Others threatened to kill themselves. One interviewed by The Washington Post said he attempted it.

During his two weeks at the Guantánamo Bay naval station, Uzcátegui, 27, said he was rarely let outside. Both times, he was shackled and placed in what he described as a cage. It was the only sight of the blue Cuban sky he got, so otherworldly it felt like a dream.

"They didn't treat me like a human being," he said, his voice

flustered with indignation. "They threw me in a cage."

The Trump administration flew nearly 180 migrants from the United States to Guantánamo and deported all of them to Venezuela on Thursday. The Post spoke with three men who were detained in the U.S. military prison that has been used to house suspected terrorists since the Sept. 11, 2001, attacks. All had crossed the border illegally, and although Homeland Security Secretary Kristi L. Noem called the migrants transported to Cuba the "worst of the worst," The Post could find no other criminal record for those interviewed.

Uzcátegui, José Daniel Simancas and Franyer Montes said they were denied calls to lawyers or loved ones after repeated pleas. They said they were subjected to humiliating and invasive strip searches. They described prolonged periods in isolation, with only two one-hour opportunities to go outside over two weeks.

Their testimonies echoed the fears expressed by human rights groups — that migrants transferred to a place known for its isolation and history of torture allegations could be vulnerable to abuse.

The migrants' conditions in

SEE **MIGRANTS** ON **A14**

Refugees: A judge put Trump's ban on admissions on hold. **A3**

The trip home: Giving up on the U.S., migrants face new risks. **A10**

IN THE NEWS

Disbursal of USAID funds A judge ordered the Trump administration to pay out hundreds of millions of dollars that have been in limbo since a previous court directive. **A4**

Astir in the South Pacific For the first time in 26 years, three tropical cyclones are active simultaneously in the ocean basin. **A9**

THE NATION
The Supreme Court ordered a new trial for a death row inmate in Oklahoma. **A2**
The White House will decide which journalists cover it, an unprecedented move for control. **A8**

THE WORLD
An unknown illness has killed at least 53 people in Congo. **A11**
Russian gas giant Gazprom is stumbling toward a more modest future after losing the European market. **A15**

THE ECONOMY
About 4 in 5 Americans generally don't use AI at work, a survey found, though the technology worries many. **A16**
A lawsuit accused the Trump administration of trying to rewrite civil rights law in its threat to pull school funding over mentions of race. **A18**

THE REGION
The man accused of plotting to kill Supreme Court Justice Brett M. Kavanaugh was properly questioned, prosecutors said. **B1**
D.C.-area colleges contribute over \$15 billion to the region's economy and employ 100,000 people, a study found. **B1**

STYLE
Era-defining singer Roberta Flack, who died Monday at 88, got her start singing about eternity inside a small bar in the District. **C1**
FOOD
Stephen Starr is doubling down on the D.C. dining scene with a reimagined Occidental. **E1**

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